sufficiently close to the valley bottom to be well within the range of the Afghans' jezails. Now, once the front of the British column had entered far within the towering cliffs of the pass – making no attempt to send up flankers to crown the heights as should by now have been automatic drill for the infantry – the ambush was sprung. 'We had not proceeded half a mile when we were heavily fired upon,' wrote Lady Sale that night. 'The Chiefs who rode with the advance desired us to keep close to them. They certainly desired their followers to shout to the people on the heights not to fire; but they did so quite ineffectually. These Chiefs certainly ran the same risks we did; but I verily believe many of these persons would individually sacrifice themselves to rid their country of us.'[ff] She continued:

> After passing through some very sharp firing, we came upon Major Thain's horse, which had been shot through the loins. When we were supposed to be in comparative safety, poor Sturt rode back, to see after Major Thain: his horse was shot from under him, and before he could rise from the ground, he received a severe wound in the abdomen. It was with great difficulty that he was held upon a pony by two people, and brought into camp at Khoord Kabul.
>
> The pony Mrs Sturt rode was wounded in the ear and neck. I had fortunately only one ball in my arm; three others passed through my *poshteen* [posting – 'long skin', i.e. sheepskin coat] near the shoulder without doing me injury. The party that fired on us were not fifty yards from us, and we owed our escape to urging our horses on as fast as they could go over the road where, at any other time, we would have walked our horses very carefully*?*. . .?

The pass quickly became jammed, and 'for a considerable period we were stationary under heavy fire . . . The 37th [Regiment] continued moving slowly forward without firing a shot, being paralysed with cold to such a degree that no persuasion of their officers could induce them to make any effort to dislodge the enemy, who took from some of them not only their firelocks but even the clothes from their person; several men of the 44th supplied themselves with ammunition from the pouches of their *sipahees* [sepoys] . . . All this time our men were dropping fast from a flanking fire from the heights . . . [At least] 500 of our regular troops, and about 2,500 of our camp followers, are killed?. . .'[41]

Yet according to those who followed, the first wave of troops in which Lady Sale was travelling got off comparatively lightly. 'The advance, altho' they suffered considerably, was by comparison with the rear very fortunate,' wrote Hugh Johnson.

> There the scene of slaughter was dreadful. We had to run the gauntlet of the whole length of this fearful defile, a distance of about 5 miles. All baggage was abandoned. The enemy not only